# PGS Kiosk Manager 4.1

## User Guide and Instructions

A small Windows tool for administrators that turns individual restrictions on or off for standard (non-administrator) local user accounts. It saves a backup before every change, so any user can be put back exactly as they were.

| Item | Details |
|---|---|
| Runs on | Windows 10 and Windows 11 (Pro, Enterprise, Education; Home with limits) |
| Requires | Windows PowerShell 5.1 (built in). An administrator account. No installation. |
| Manages | Enabled local standard users. Administrators are never listed or changed. |
| Backups | C:\ProgramData\PGS-Kiosk-Manager\Backups\<user>\ (one JSON file per change) |
| Log | C:\ProgramData\PGS-Kiosk-Manager\pgs.log |

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# 1. What is in the package

| File | Purpose |
|---|---|
| Launch-PGS-Kiosk-Manager.cmd | Double-click this to start the program. |
| PGS-Kiosk-Manager.ps1 | The window (graphical interface). |
| PGS-Engine.ps1 | Does the actual work. Can also be used from the command line. |
| README.txt | Short summary of this guide. |
| PGS-Kiosk-Manager-Guide.pdf | This guide. |

Keep the three program files together in the same folder.

# 2. Before you start

- Sign in with an **administrator** account. Keep at least one working administrator account that you never restrict.
- Every user you want to manage must have **signed in at least once**, so that Windows has created their profile. Users that never signed in are shown as *(never signed in)*.
- It is best if the users you change are **signed out**. If a user is signed in, the change is still saved, but it fully applies only after they sign out and back in.
- Extract the ZIP file to a normal folder, for example `C:\Tools\PGS-Kiosk-Manager`. Do not run it from inside the ZIP.
- Try new settings on one test account first.

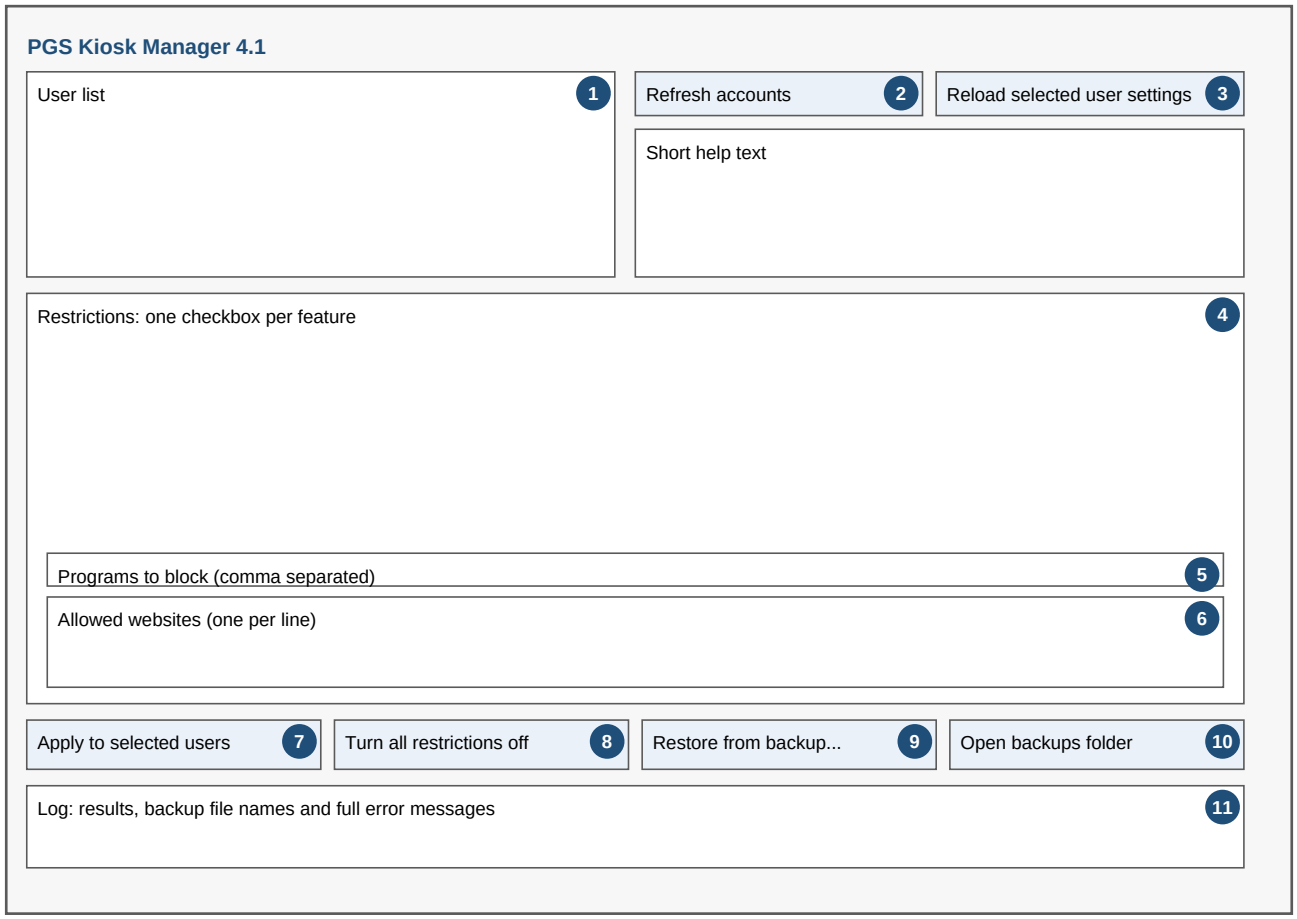
> **Tip:** To sign another user out, open Task Manager, go to the **Users** tab, right-click the user and choose **Sign off**. Restarting the PC also works.

# 3. Starting the program

1. Open the folder where you extracted the files.
2. Double-click **Launch-PGS-Kiosk-Manager.cmd**.
3. Windows asks "Do you want to allow this app to make changes?". Click **Yes**.
4. The PGS Kiosk Manager window opens and lists the standard users of this PC.

> **If Windows SmartScreen warns you:** click **More info** and then **Run anyway**. You can also right-click the ZIP file before extracting, choose **Properties** and tick **Unblock**.

# 4. The main window




| # | Part | What it does |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | User list | Standard local users. Click one user to see their current settings. Hold Ctrl or Shift to select several users. |
| 2 | Refresh accounts | Reloads the user list (for example after you created a new user). |
| 3 | Reload selected user settings | Reads the selected user's settings again and updates the checkboxes. |
| 4 | Restrictions | One checkbox per restriction. Checked = ON, unchecked = OFF. |
| 5 | Programs to block | The program list used by "Block the programs listed below". |
| 6 | Allowed websites | The website whitelist used by "Allow only the websites listed below". One site per line, no http:// or https://. |
| 7 | Apply to selected users | Makes the selected users match the checkboxes exactly. Saves a backup first. |
| 8 | Turn all restrictions off | Removes every restriction this tool manages. Saves a backup first. |
| 9 | Restore from backup... | Puts one user back exactly as a backup file recorded. |
| 10 | Open backups folder | Opens the backups folder in File Explorer. |
| 11 | Log | Shows what happened, the backup file name for each change, and full error messages. |

# 5. Step by step: common tasks

## A. See what is currently restricted for a user

1. Click the user in the list.
2. The checkboxes change to show that user's current settings.
3. The log shows a line such as *PaulS: current restrictions: TaskManager, RunMenu*.

## B. Restrict one or more users

1. Select the user (or several users with Ctrl/Shift).
2. Tick the restrictions you want ON and untick the ones you want OFF.
3. If you use program blocking, check the list of programs in the text box.
4. Click **Apply to selected users** and confirm with **Yes**.
5. Read the log: it shows the backup file and the restrictions that are now active.
6. If the user was signed in, ask them to sign out and back in.

> **Important:** Apply sets **every** restriction. Anything unticked is turned OFF for the selected users. When you select several users, the checkboxes show the last single user you clicked, so check them before you click Apply.

## C. Turn one restriction off and leave the others

1. Click the user, so the checkboxes show their current settings.
2. Untick only the restriction you want to remove.
3. Click **Apply to selected users**.

## D. Remove all restrictions (for maintenance)

1. Select the user(s).
2. Click **Turn all restrictions off** and confirm.
3. When you are done, click the user again, tick the restrictions and Apply. Or use Restore with the backup made just before you turned them off.

## E. Undo a change

1. Select exactly one user.
2. Click **Restore from backup...**.
3. The user's backup folder opens. Pick the file from **before** the change you want to undo (file names contain the date, time and action, for example `PaulS-20261009-143012-120-before-apply.json`).
4. Confirm with **Yes**. A new backup of the current state is made first, so a restore can also be undone.

# 6. The restrictions explained

All restrictions are standard Windows per-user policies, written into the selected user's own registry. Other users on the PC are not affected (the Store block also adds one AppLocker rule, see section 7).

| Checkbox | Name on command line | Effect for the user |
|---|---|---|
| Hide drive icons in This PC | HideDrives | Drives A-Z are hidden in This PC. Desktop, Documents, Downloads and other personal folders still work. |
| Disable Task Manager | TaskManager | Task Manager cannot be opened (also not from Ctrl+Alt+Del). |
| Disable Command Prompt | CommandPrompt | cmd.exe shows "disabled by your administrator". Batch files and logon scripts still run. |
| Block Settings app and Control Panel | ControlPanel | Settings and Control Panel cannot be opened. |
| Remove Run from Start menu | RunMenu | Win+R and the Run command are removed. |
| Disable Registry Editor | RegistryTools | regedit cannot be opened. |
| Prevent changing the wallpaper | Wallpaper | The desktop background cannot be changed. |
| Block Microsoft Store | Store | The Microsoft Store app is blocked for this user. See section 7. |
| Allow only the websites listed below | Websites | Edge, Chrome and Brave open only the websites in the list. Every other website is blocked. See section 8. |
| Block the programs listed below | ShellBlock | Programs in the text box cannot be started from the Start menu, desktop or File Explorer. Use file names such as `notepad.exe`. |

Default list of blocked programs: powershell.exe, powershell_ise.exe, pwsh.exe, cmd.exe, wt.exe (Terminal), regedit.exe, reg.exe, mmc.exe. You can add or remove names, separated by commas.

# 7. Blocking the Microsoft Store

The **Block Microsoft Store** option does two things for the selected user:

- It sets the Windows policy "Turn off the Store application" for that user. Windows only enforces this policy on Enterprise and Education editions.
- On Pro, Enterprise and Education, it also adds an **AppLocker** rule that denies the Microsoft Store app to that one user. This is what reliably blocks the Store on Windows Pro.

The first time you block the Store for anyone, the tool turns on AppLocker rules for packaged (Store-style) apps on the PC and adds the standard Windows rule "All signed packaged apps" for Everyone. That keeps every other app working for every user; only the PGS deny rules take effect. It also starts the **Application Identity** service, which AppLocker needs.

Turning the option off removes that user's AppLocker rule again. Restoring a backup puts the rule back exactly as it was at the time of that backup.

**Windows Home:** Home editions do not have AppLocker. The tool still sets the Store policy and tells you in the log that Windows may ignore it.

**Domain or Intune PCs:** AppLocker rules from Group Policy or Intune are combined with the local rules this tool adds. If AppLocker is set to Audit-only by your organisation, the Store is logged but not blocked, and the log tells you so.

# 8. Website whitelist

With **Allow only the websites listed below** ticked, the selected user can open only the websites in the **Allowed websites** box. Every other website shows "blocked by your organisation".

## How to enter websites

- One website per line (commas also work).
- Type only the site name, for example `google.com`. Do **not** type `http://`, `https://` or `www.`; the tool removes them if you do.
- `example.com` also allows every subdomain, such as `www.example.com` and `mail.example.com`, on http and https.
- To allow only part of a site, add a path: `example.com/school`.
- Click a user to see the websites currently allowed for them.

| You type | The tool saves | Allowed |
|---|---|---|
| https://www.Google.com/ | google.com | google.com and all *.google.com |
| wikipedia.org | wikipedia.org | wikipedia.org, en.wikipedia.org, ... |
| *.microsoft.com | microsoft.com | microsoft.com and all subdomains |
| docs.example.com/guide | docs.example.com/guide | only that part of docs.example.com |

## Which browsers are covered

- **Microsoft Edge, Google Chrome and Brave**: the whitelist is applied as a per-user browser policy.
- **Firefox, Opera and other browsers are not covered.** Add their program names (for example `firefox.exe, opera.exe`) to the **Programs to block** list and tick program blocking. The tool reminds you of this when you click Apply.
- Close and reopen the browser after a change. To check, open `edge://policy` or `chrome://policy`: you should see URLBlocklist and URLAllowlist.

**Sites that look broken:** many websites load pictures, videos or sign-in pages from other domains. If a page loads only partly, add those domains too. Examples: YouTube also needs `ytimg.com` and `googlevideo.com`; Google sign-in uses `accounts.google.com` (already covered by google.com). Microsoft 365 sign-in needs `microsoftonline.com`, `live.com` and `office.com`.

# 9. Backups and restoring

- Before every Apply, Turn off or Restore, the tool records the user's current values for every restriction it manages, plus the blocked program list and the Store AppLocker rule.
- The backup is written to `C:\ProgramData\PGS-Kiosk-Manager\Backups\<user>\` and read back to check that it saved correctly. If that fails, nothing is changed.
- File name format: `<user>-<yyyyMMdd-HHmmss-fff>-before-<action>.json`
- Only Administrators and SYSTEM can open the PGS-Kiosk-Manager folder.
- A backup can only be restored to the same user on the same PC (the tool checks the user's SID).
- Backups made by version 3.0 can also be restored.
- Backups are never deleted automatically. You may delete old ones yourself.

> **Good practice:** The oldest "before-apply" backup of a user is their original state from before you first used the tool. Keep that file.

# 10. Command-line use

Everything can also be done from an elevated PowerShell window (right-click Start, **Terminal (Admin)**), from the program folder:

```
cd C:\Tools\PGS-Kiosk-Manager
Set-ExecutionPolicy -Scope Process Bypass

.\PGS-Engine.ps1 -Action Users
.\PGS-Engine.ps1 -Action Inspect -UserName PaulS
.\PGS-Engine.ps1 -Action Apply -UserName PaulS,HayleyM -Enable
TaskManager,RunMenu,Store,ShellBlock
.\PGS-Engine.ps1 -Action Apply -UserName PaulS -Enable Websites -AllowedSites
"google.com,wikipedia.org"
.\PGS-Engine.ps1 -Action Apply -UserName PaulS -Enable ShellBlock -BlockedApps
"cmd.exe,notepad.exe"
.\PGS-Engine.ps1 -Action Clear -UserName PaulS
.\PGS-Engine.ps1 -Action Restore -UserName PaulS -BackupFile
"C:\ProgramData\PGS-Kiosk-Manager\Backups\PaulS\<file>.json"
```

**-Enable** lists the restrictions to turn ON (names from the table in section 6); all others are turned OFF. Without **-BlockedApps** the default program list is used. **-AllowedSites** is the website whitelist. The script exits with code 1 if any user failed.

# 11. Troubleshooting

| Message or problem | What to do |
|---|---|
| A user is missing from the list | Only enabled, non-administrator local accounts are shown. Check the account in Computer Management > Local Users and Groups, then click Refresh accounts. |
| "... has no Windows profile yet" | Sign in as that user once, sign out, then try again. |
| "Could not open the registry of ..." | The user is not fully signed out, or another program holds their profile. Sign them off in Task Manager > Users, or restart the PC. |
| "Could not release the temporary registry copy..." | Restart the PC before that user signs in. Their settings were saved correctly. |
| "... is signed in right now" | Not an error. Ask the user to sign out and back in. |
| A restriction does not seem to work | Make sure the user signed out and in again. Local Group Policy, Intune/MDM or other tools can override these settings. Windows Home ignores some policies. |
| A website from the list is blocked | Check the spelling, close and reopen the browser, and look at edge://policy or chrome://policy. Add any helper domains the site needs (see section 8). |
| Websites are not blocked | The user may be using Firefox or another browser: block it with the program list. Make sure the user signed out and in, and the browser was restarted. |
| The Store still opens | On Home, see section 7. On Pro: check that the Application Identity service is running (services.msc) and that the user signed out and in. |
| "Apply failed ... The settings from before are saved in ..." | Use Restore from backup with the file named in the message. |
| The window is too tall for the screen | The window scrolls; you can also maximise it. |
| Anything else | Copy the text from the log box and the last lines of `C:\ProgramData\PGS-Kiosk-Manager\pgs.log`. |

# 12. Limitations and safety

- These are per-user Windows policies. They make misuse harder but are **not** a security-grade single-app kiosk.
- Program blocking only stops programs started through Explorer (Start menu, desktop, double-click). A program started in another way may still run.
- Local Group Policy, Intune/MDM or other management software can override these settings.
- Windows Home may ignore some policies and has no AppLocker.
- Always keep a separate administrator account that is never restricted.
- Do not delete user accounts or profiles to "reset" them; use Turn all restrictions off or Restore instead.